

EMOTIVE TECHNIQUES

REBT practitioners use a variety of emotive procedures. These strategies are used both during the therapy sessions and as homework assignments in daily life. Their purpose is not simply to provide a cathartic experience but to help clients *change* some of their thoughts, emotions, and behaviors.

● ***Rational emotive imagery.***

Rational Emotive Imagery was **invented** in 1971 by Dr. Maxie Maultsby, Jr. and used effectively by him in his clinical work and later used by Dr. Albert Ellis. This technique is a form of intense mental practice designed to establish new emotional patterns (see Ellis, 2001a, 2001b).

Rational Emotive Imagery (REI) is a way of practicing correcting your emotional reaction to some real or imagined event. You practice imagining this dreaded event and then practice experiencing an appropriate negative emotion instead of the typical, self-defeating negative emotion you normally would feel.

Rationale: Humans have the capacity to correct their emotional reactions by using their powers of imagination.

When a person enters a situation where they have previously experienced a negative emotion **such as** anxiety and not concern, or anger and not annoyance, or depression and not sadness, the emotion may be reminded by the memory of the previously experienced emotion (which was created by a demand and inaccurate definition not a preference). Memory is most vulnerable to change at this point (February 2003, New Scientist magazine "Not so Total Recall").

In REI the client is asked to close their eyes and to re-create that problematic situation in their mind's eye, then to experience the emotion. The client is then encouraged to change the emotion

(created by the demand). For some clients, rising above and more objectively and philosophically identifying the emotion for one minute and then changing their view or beliefs about the situation silently through their own self talk, – and often acknowledging that she/he may not like that emotion or the situation but they can accept that initial feeling and unconditionally accept themselves – they find they have changed the unhealthy emotion and are experiencing a healthier one.

Steps:

1. Imagine in vivid detail some negative event, set of circumstances, etc. This **dreaded event** could be something that **has already happened** to you or something you fear could happen **in the future**. It **could be a** rejection, a fear, a failure, an act of criticism, becoming ill, developing acne, being fired, being laughed at etc.
2. **Get in touch with** the anxiety, anger, embarrassment, shame, depression, unhealthy anger, unhealthy jealousy, and unhealthy envy feelings **that typically go** with the dreaded scenario. Really imagine the scenario and get in touch with and feel the associated emotion.
3. Next **assume you can do** something to change your emotion without changing the imagined dreaded scenario. Repeat – do not change the dreaded scenario. In REBT, we talk about appropriate negative emotions. **So change your** typical self-defeating negative emotion to a healthy, adaptive, self-enhancing, appropriate negative emotion. **So** force yourself, will yourself, choose to feel a healthy negative emotion while still imagining the dreaded event. **Go from feeling** anxiety, anger, embarrassment, shame, or depression to feeling only concern, annoyance, displeasure, sorrow, regret, remorse, sadness, disappointment, healthy envy, healthy jealousy, or healthy anger.

Note: The most important thing is not change the dreaded imagined scenario when you attempt to change your feeling. *You have to hold onto the dreaded scenario but imagine feeling differently about it.*

4. In order to do this you may have to imagine yourself thinking differently about the dreaded imagine scenario.
5. Practice this once a day. It sounds like a silly exercise but if you do it, practice choosing a different emotion in time you will see you can dictate how you feel about certain dreaded scenarios. Try this every day for one month. It takes three to five minutes to do and is not very difficult. If it works after a month you have gained quite a bit. If it doesn't you have lost very little. Try it and see!

Note: REBT is about choosing your emotional destiny. You can choose your emotions to different scenarios. It does take practice but it can be done.

Forceful Coping Statements

Forceful Coping Statements: While Rational Coping Statements can work wonders when repeated, it often helps to make them more forcefully, even shouting them out. "I shall overcome!"

Forceful self-statements that fight "musturbating" beliefs in a strong and forceful manner can be helpful in replacing irrational beliefs with rational beliefs. If a client has told himself that it is awful and terrible to get a C on an examination, this self-statement can be replaced by a forceful and more suitable statement such as "I want to get an A, but I don't have to!" Ellis often uses offensiveness as a way of providing more force to a statement (Dryden & Ellis, 2003).

Use of force and vigor. Ellis has suggested the use of force and energy as a way to help clients go from intellectual to emotional insight. Clients are also shown how to conduct forceful dialogues with themselves in which they express their unproven beliefs and then powerfully dispute them. Sometimes the therapist will engage in **reverse role playing** by strongly clinging to the client's self-defeating philosophy. Then, the client is asked to forcefully debate with the therapist in an attempt to persuade him or her to give up these dysfunctional ideas. While the client tries to convince the therapist that the belief is dysfunctional. Force and energy are a basic part of shame-attacking exercises.

Ellis and Dryden (1997) endorsed the use of forceful self-statements and self-dialogue as emotive techniques. This is where individuals devise rational statements and argue the appropriateness of their rational/irrational beliefs.

Role play and Reverse Role Playing

Introduction

Role play exercises are used in everyday life. When preparing for an interview, a big presentation, or any other major event, people often practice ahead of time by running through potential scenarios.

Role Playing – repeated role playing of the situation gives the individual a chance to feel better about her social skills and change inappropriate emotional self statements (Ellis, 1986)

Role playing has emotive, cognitive, and behavioral components, and the therapist often interrupts to show clients what they are telling themselves to create their disturbances and what they can do to change their unhealthy feelings to healthy ones. Clients can rehearse certain behaviors to bring out what they feel in a

situation. The focus is on working through the underlying irrational beliefs that are related to unpleasant feelings.

This practice allows people to feel more confident in their situation, reduces anxiety, and prepares a person to deal with difficult situations or questions. Role play therapy can be a big benefit to many different people in treatment by preparing them for future situations that they may face.

Role-playing exercises can take place between two or more people and may be applied to nearly any area of life. These exercises are most effectively used to address difficult and unfamiliar topics, and may be used to deal with emotionally difficult conversations or to resolve conflict.

Acting out scenarios can help identify ways in which people may respond to situations and create new approaches to particular events. It can also serve to identify behaviors that may be counter-productive or find the most effective ways to handle situations. Role-playing can also provide insight into what others may feel about a situation.

This form of therapy is used in individual, group, and family therapies. Role-Playing Therapy focuses on patients who have phobias and want to overcome them by learning new behaviors. The sessions will consist of the therapist taking the role of someone who may be difficult for the patient to confront. When the client is interacting with the counselor they will use the new behaviors that have been taught to them during treatment.

Many people suffer from social or interpersonal fears that prevent them from participating in many activities. Role-Playing Therapy can help individuals overcome the fears by breaking the habit and learning new behavioral techniques.

How well the treatment plan works is going to depend on how severe the fear is. There are some phobias that cannot be cured

although therapy can help people function when in the given situation.

For example, Dawson may put off applying to a graduate school because of his fears of not being accepted. Just the thought of not being accepted to the school of his choice brings out intense feelings of “being stupid.” Dawson role-plays an interview with the dean of graduate students, notes his anxiety and the specific beliefs leading to it, and challenges his conviction that he absolutely must be accepted and that not gaining such acceptance means that he is a stupid and incompetent person.

How to Conduct Role-Play Exercises

Setting up a role-playing session in treatment can be easy and effective. There are several steps that can be used to guide a session:

1. **Identifying the situation:** Before beginning, it is important to identify the situation that will be addressed. This will help encourage discussion about a particular topic and ensure relevant information is discussed. In group therapy settings, it is important to have open discussion and invite people to participate in icebreaker exercises if they are unfamiliar with others in the group.
2. **Include details:** Role-playing exercises should be made to feel as real as possible. Be sure to include details about the situation so that the problem and solutions become more relevant. If there is a desired outcome, details can help guide the role-playing exercise in the right direction.
3. **Assign roles:** Whether it is a group activity or a one-on-one session between a client and therapist, assigning roles can **help people learn how** to deal with a situation. Having people **change roles can** also help them think about a situation more broadly and better understand how to handle

it. **By introducing different** emotions and perspectives, clients can better imagine how others may think, feel, or respond to situations while gaining insight into their own perspective.

4. **Act it out:** In role-playing exercises, clients should act out situations using different approaches to learn how to handle situations more effectively. Acting out these events can help clients better understand approaches to difficult topics, and learn what is most effective when dealing with different scenarios.
5. **Discuss what was learned:** Following a role-playing exercise, it is important to discuss what was learned. This can help clients better understand themselves as well as those around them, leading to better interactions in future situations.

Goals of Role-Playing Therapy

The purpose of Role-Playing Therapy is to help the patient overcome their individual fear. The most common treatments are towards those who have phobia of social interaction which can prevent them from participating in many activities. By going to therapy the counselor will work with the patient individually so that they can overcome this issue and develop new ways of thinking and acting which helps them overcome the challenge and enjoy more aspects of life.

At times the phobia is the result of a traumatic situation. The therapist will diagnose the client to get to the root of the fear first and then clarify any memories that may be associated with it. By eliminating the fears and allowing the patient to see that it is an illusion they can begin using the techniques that they've learned during the session and execute them outside of therapy.

How Role-Playing Therapy Works

Treatment works by **gradually** exposing the patient to the situation through role-playing **and rehearsal**. They will learn methods in reducing the amount of anxiety they experience. These methods will provide them with courage and help them relax when nervous feelings begin taking over. The best treatment method is slowly moving the client into the place or situation in which the phobia sets in. The counselor will teach the patient relaxation techniques, deep breathing and demonstrate biofeedback.

Being that there are some fears that cannot be cured there is medication to help patients who are affected by it heavily. The medications are used with therapy although they usually are not prescribed until the counselor is aware of the severity. The medications that are most effective in treating social phobias are antidepressants and SSRIs.

By the end of treatment the patient should be able to approach their situation slowly while working on learned relaxation components. If the desensitization proceeds it will gain enough momentum so that it overcomes the presence of fear in a situation that isn't harmful. The key to Role-Playing Therapy is slow progress and gradually learning the new target behavior which can be accomplished using imagination, trust in the therapist and gradual courage.

Humor

Humor has been employed as a therapeutic strategy in cognitive [therapy](#) for many years. Albert Ellis, the founder of Rational Emotive Behavior Therapy (REBT), consistently used humor to help people get outside themselves and observe themselves as others might.

REBT contends that emotional disturbances often result from taking oneself too seriously. One appealing aspects of REBT is that it fosters the development of a better sense of humor and helps put life into perspective (Wolfe, 2007).

Humor has both cognitive and emotional benefits in bringing about change. Humor shows the silliness of certain ideas that clients consistently maintain, and it can be of value in helping clients take themselves much less seriously.

Ellis (2001a) himself tends to use a good deal of humor to combat exaggerated thinking that leads clients into trouble. In his workshops and therapy sessions, Ellis typically uses humorous songs, and he encourages people to sing to themselves or in groups when they feel depressed or anxious (Ellis, 1999, 2001a, 2001b). His style of presenting is humorous and he seems to enjoy using words like "horseshit!"

Encounter Exercises

These techniques can include:

- Relaxation
- Hypnosis
- Meditation
- Mindfulness
- Breathing exercises